



The Lane You Picked Is Not the Lane You Swim

Validating a Self-Report Pace Scale Against the Stopwatch

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Background

Public pools sort swimmers into lanes by self-declared pace, never checked against a stopwatch. How far does that self-report drift from a timed lap, and what does the drift do to a crowding index built on headcount alone?

Research questions

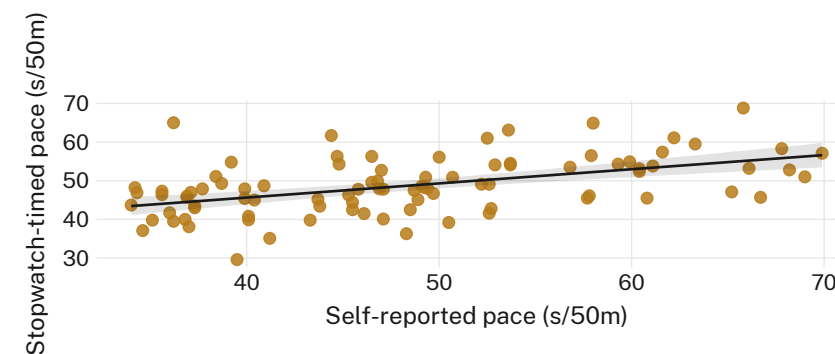
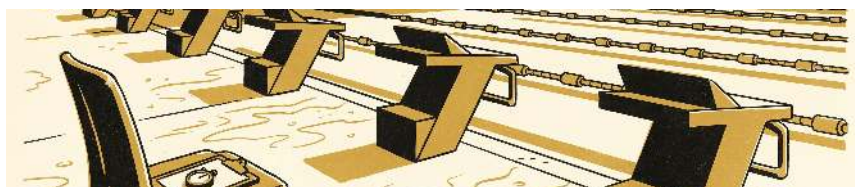
- Does declared pace predict a stopwatch-timed 50 m split?
- Does the mismatch vary by band and session time?
- Does it out-predict a crowding index better than headcount?

Approach

- $n = 90$ · 6 suburban lap pools · hand-timed 50 m splits · 14 weeks
- 3-item pace scale at lane entry; timed pace regressed on declared pace
- Lane and session time held constant across paired passes

What we found

Declared pace explains only part of timed variance. The mismatch is patterned by band, not random, and peaks in the evening session.



Declared and timed pace correlate only moderately ($r = 0.50$, $n = 90$). Fast-band swimmers overshoot their split by 7.1 s on average; slow-band swimmers undersell theirs by 8.3 s.

What it means & where next

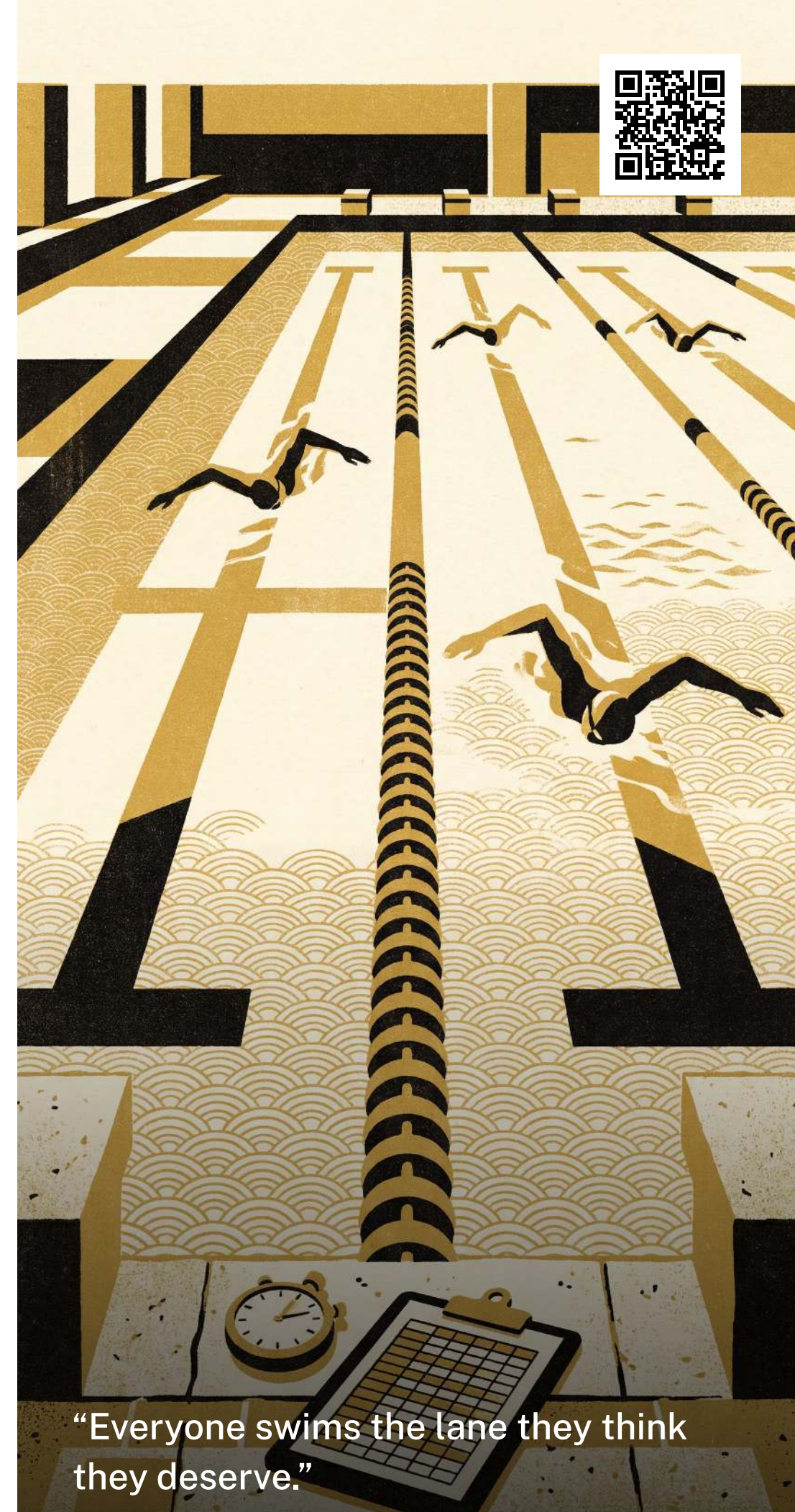
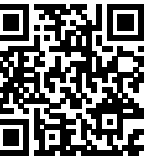
Fast-band overclaiming concentrates in the unsupervised 6-8pm session. Folding the drift into the index tracks lane pressure a headcount misses. Next: field the drift-adjusted index network-wide.

Selected references

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3. Lin, H., Ma, Z., Ji, R., Wang, Y., & Hong, X. (2022). Boosting crowd counting via multifaceted attention. *arXiv:2203.02636*
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Human ethics approval 2026/031; times recorded without swimmer names; self-report forms de-identified at entry.

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“Everyone swims the lane they think they deserve.”

Self-report vs. stopwatch, six pools, 14 weeks.